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POLITICS OF EUROPEAN INTEGRATION: CLASSROOM EXERCISE

# Negotiating the Treaty of Belfield

*A 50-minute Intergovernmental Conference simulation in which eight member-state delegations negotiate a treaty amendment on EU defence under a unanimity rule.*

Topic tags: Intergovernmental Conference · treaty reform · CSDP and Article 42 TEU · EU Battlegroups · unanimity and the veto · coalition building

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## Abstract

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This simulation places students inside the closing stage of an Intergovernmental Conference (IGC), the treaty-making forum in which EU member states negotiate changes to the founding Treaties. Eight delegations represent France, Germany, Hungary, Ireland, Italy, the Netherlands, Poland and Spain, each working from a national brief. On the table is the fictional “Treaty of Belfield”, a draft amendment to Article 42 TEU (the Common Security and Defence Policy) that would strengthen the EU Battlegroups by creating a standing force, increasing armaments and interoperability, and funding this by reallocating money from the Union’s sustainability funds. The organising team plays the President of the IGC, who chairs proceedings and, at the end, consolidates the delegations’ proposed amendments into a revised draft. Each delegation makes a one-minute opening pitch, then negotiates freely for twenty minutes to build coalitions and trade concessions before the amended treaty is put to a final vote. Because treaty reform requires unanimity, any single veto blocks adoption. The exercise makes visible the sources of bargaining power at an IGC, the way treaty language is watered down to accommodate divergent states, and the decisive weight of the veto.

## Learning outcomes

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By the end of this exercise students will be able to:

- Explain how treaty reform is negotiated at an Intergovernmental Conference and why the unanimity requirement gives every member state a veto.
- Identify the sources of a state’s bargaining power at an IGC (economic weight, military capacity, geography, coalition options) and how domestic constraints condition that power.
- Analyse how coalition building, horse-trading and side payments shape a negotiated outcome, and how precise treaty wording (“shall” versus “may”) becomes an object of bargaining.
- Evaluate critically why treaty change is so difficult to achieve, and reflect on how the veto both protects national interests and produces gridlock or watered-down outcomes.

## At a glance

|                             |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |
|-----------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Duration</b>             | 50 minutes of simulation, plus 15–20 minutes debrief                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |
| <b>Class size</b>           | 16–40 students in 8 delegations, plus a 2–4 person organising team playing the IGC President                                                                                                                                                                                                     |
| <b>Room setup</b>           | One room, moveable seating; a labelled table or cluster per country; projector or screen for the shared treaty text                                                                                                                                                                              |
| <b>Materials needed</b>     | This instructor guide; the draft treaty handout; the eight country briefs (one per delegation); a projected slide with the scenario, timeline and voting rule; a shared editable copy of the treaty text (see preparation); optional printed country flags or name cards to mark each delegation |
| <b>Instructor prep time</b> | 45–60 minutes (allocate delegations, print or share briefs, set up the shared treaty document, rehearse the President role)                                                                                                                                                                      |
| <b>Student prep time</b>    | 15–20 minutes reading the country brief and the draft treaty in advance                                                                                                                                                                                                                          |

## Pre-class preparation

### For the instructor

- Divide the class into eight delegations of roughly 2–5 students: France, Germany, Hungary, Ireland, Italy, the Netherlands, Poland and Spain. The organising team (2–4 people) plays the President of the IGC and runs the room. With a smaller class, drop delegations rather than shrinking below two per group; with a larger class, keep groups at five and add advisor roles (see Adaptation notes) rather than adding countries.
- Distribute the relevant country brief and the draft treaty (Appendix B) to each delegation at least a day before class. Sending materials in advance materially improves the session: students arrive knowing their objectives, and the short in-class reading time is enough to firm up strategy rather than start from scratch.
- Set up a single shared, editable copy of the draft treaty text that the whole class can see and annotate during the deliberation phase. This is the amendment-tracking mechanism, so decide the format before class and test it. Two reliable options:
  - Project the treaty text on screen in an editable document and have one member of the organising team type in each proposed amendment as delegations table it, recording which countries back it.
  - Create your own shared online document (for example a word-processing document with comment or suggestion permissions) and give students comment or suggestion access, not full edit access, so the base text cannot be overwritten. If you use this route, test the permissions in

advance: set access to “view only” until the session starts, then switch to “comment” or “suggest”. In past runs, loose permissions let a participant accidentally overwrite the live text, so lock editing of the base document down and make clear that only the President’s team edits the master copy.

- Do not rely on any pre-existing shared link; build your own document fresh so you control the permissions.
- Prepare a projected slide (or handout) stating the scenario, the timeline, and the voting rule (unanimity: any single veto blocks adoption). Appendix A gives a facilitator script you can read from.
- Build your own hypotheses before class. Work out which coalitions the briefs make likely, who has most to gain, and who is positioned to veto. Because the organising team chairs the conference and later drafts the revised text, they must be on top of every delegation’s position.
- Decide in advance who on the team plays the President. If two or more staff are available, one can chair while another records amendments and keeps time.
- Optionally, print country name cards or flags to mark each delegation’s table and structure the room. Flags are a prop only; they also make a neat show-of-flags final vote (see the session plan), but the exercise runs perfectly well without them.

### For students

- Read your country brief and the draft treaty beforehand. Note where your country can accept the text, where the wording needs to change, and where a proposal (especially the funding source) is a problem.
- Come ready to argue your assigned national position, setting aside your own views. Each brief flags the country’s stance on the three linked proposals: **what** (strengthen the Battlegroups), **how** (a standing force, armaments and interoperability), and **where the money comes from** (reallocating sustainability funds).
- Identify in advance which other delegations look like natural allies and which look like obstacles.

## Session plan

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The simulation runs to 50 minutes. Each delegation nominates one **spokesperson**, who delivers the opening pitch and casts the delegation’s vote. The remaining members act as **advisors**: during deliberation they move between tables, sound out coalitions, and report back so the spokesperson can adjust the delegation’s amendments. The President of the IGC (organising team) chairs throughout, keeps strict time, and keeps proceedings orderly.

| Time      | Phase                               | What happens                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
|-----------|-------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 0:00–0:05 | Introduction and strategy           | The President sets the scene (Appendix A script), confirms the timeline and the unanimity rule, and takes an initial show-of-hands vote on the draft as it stands (this anchors how far positions move by the end). Delegations read their brief, agree a one-minute pitch, and nominate a spokesperson.                                                                                                            |
| 0:05–0:15 | Tour de table                       | Guided by the President, each spokesperson gives a one-minute pitch: what their country accepts, what wording must change, and whether the funding source is a problem. The President stops each pitch at one minute. Advisors take notes on each position and on which delegations to approach.                                                                                                                    |
| 0:15–0:35 | Deliberation and coalition building | Students move freely between tables to build coalitions and horse-trade. There is no limit on how many delegations can talk at once. As agreements form, delegations table amendments in the shared treaty document, naming every backing country; one person can record a jointly backed amendment. The President circulates, keeps delegations to time, and nudges any delegation that is holding back to engage. |
| 0:35–0:40 | Drafting the revised treaty         | Delegations take a short break. The President's team consolidates the tabled amendments into a revised draft, weighting each change by how much support it attracted and how effectively the President was lobbied, aiming for a text that can pass. The team focuses on changing the treaty's language and adding or cutting                                                                                       |

| Time      | Phase                       | What happens                                                                                                                                                                              |
|-----------|-----------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
|           |                             | clauses to reflect the amendments.                                                                                                                                                        |
| 0:40–0:50 | Presentation and final vote | The President walks the class through the revised treaty in full, explaining each change and linking it to the amendment that prompted it. Each delegation then votes to adopt or reject. |

### The amendment mechanism (make this explicit to students)

- A delegation may table an amendment alone; it does not need to line up backers first. Independent amendments are still considered, but their chance of making the revised draft depends on the support they later attract. Say this at the start, because past groups wrongly assumed they needed backing before they could propose anything.
- Push delegations to specify exact wording. The single most useful instruction is to make them argue over language: changing “shall” to “may”, capping the sum drawn from sustainability funds, adding an opt-in clause. Vague amendments give the President little to work with.
- If, roughly twelve minutes into deliberation, nothing has been tabled in the shared document, apply pressure in role: “It is the final day of the conference, the media are waiting outside, we need a tangible outcome.” This mirrors real IGC endgame dynamics and gets amendments onto paper.

### Voting rule: unanimity

- Treaty reform requires the agreement of every member state. The vote is taken delegation by delegation (a show of flags, if you are using them, is a nice touch). Unless **all eight** delegations vote yes, the treaty does not pass. A single veto blocks adoption.
- Do not treat a failed vote as a failure of the exercise. An IGC deadlocked by one holdout is a realistic and instructive outcome; the veto is the central lesson. Whether the treaty passes or falls, the debrief draws out why.

## Debrief and reflection

Allow 15–20 minutes. The debrief is where the lessons land, so protect it. It helps to move chronologically, mirroring the exercise. Adapt the specific prompts to what you actually saw (for instance, name the delegation that sat out the early negotiation, or the one that switched sides). Group the questions as follows.

### Strategy and the tour de table (surface how positions are formed and signalled):

- In your planning, which points in your brief jumped out most? Did you prioritise domestic politics, economic and trade ties, or security when you built your pitch?
- Did your opening strategy survive contact with the other pitches, or did you change it after hearing them?
- With only a minute to pitch, how did you balance signalling openness to negotiate against keeping your real position hidden? Which leaves you stronger: showing your hand or concealing it?

**Deliberation and coalition building** (surface bargaining power, coalitions and the veto):

- Did you approach the delegations closest to your position first, or the hardest to convince? Why?
- Did knowing that a veto existed change how you negotiated: did it make you more or less willing to compromise?
- If a delegation held back at first (as delegations that feel strong often do), what lay behind that, and did it help or hurt them?
- Were there side payments or trades? Would they have been declared openly at a real IGC, or happened quietly in the background?
- For a delegation whose amendment made the final draft but still voted no: what was the dealbreaker? What would have secured your agreement?
- Did anyone insist on specific wording? What was the reasoning, and was it necessary to win support?

**The President's draft and the outcome** (for the organising team, and for the whole class):

- How did the President decide which amendments to include and which to drop, especially where positions clashed?
- Did the team expect the revised treaty to pass? If they expected a veto, from whom?
- Which delegation held the most power in the negotiation? Which changed the treaty least?
- Watching the text evolve, how quickly did the language get watered down to accommodate different states? What does that tell us about real treaty reform?
- Overall: what makes negotiating a treaty amendment so difficult, and how far did the unanimity rule shape everything that happened?

## Assessment suggestions

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The exercise works well ungraded. If you want assessment, keep it light:

- A short individual reflection (300–500 words) answering two or three debrief questions, tied to the study question on the sources of bargaining power and domestic constraints at IGCs.
- A participation mark for staying in role and engaging in the negotiation.
- A brief delegation note explaining the amendment the group tabled, which countries backed it, and the coalition logic behind it.

## Adaptation notes

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- **Scaling down.** Below sixteen students, drop delegations rather than shrink groups below two. A core set of France, Germany, Poland, Ireland and Hungary preserves the key fault lines: pro-integration heavyweights, a security hawk, a neutral with a constitutional constraint, and an outright opponent. Fewer vetoes make agreement easier, which is itself worth discussing.
- **Scaling up.** Keep delegations at about five and give each advisor a defined portfolio (defence, trade, domestic politics, or “relations with country X”). Rigid advisor roles stop everyone crowding the same conversation and let delegations split to negotiate on several fronts at once.

- **Sharpen or soften the conflict.** For more deadlock, harden the briefs so positions overlap less. For an easier pass, allow the funding source to be softened (a cap, or a separate defence budget line) so the most contested proposal has an obvious compromise.
- **Add an actor.** With a larger organising team, have one member play a disruptive or helpful external actor (for example a finance or central-bank voice pressing on the cost of reallocating funds), or lean into the option for delegations to lobby the President directly. The lobbying route was under-used in past runs, so introduce it explicitly if you want it to matter: tell delegations they may make their case to the President before the drafting break, and that persuasive lobbying weights their amendment.
- **Online delivery.** Put each delegation in its own breakout room, keep the shared treaty document on screen, let delegations visit each other's rooms during deliberation, and run the final vote by on-camera show of hands or a poll.
- **Different topic.** The structure (brief, tour de table, free deliberation with tabled amendments, a chair's consolidated draft, a unanimity vote) transfers to any IGC-style negotiation. Swap the draft treaty and the briefs and keep the mechanics.



## Appendix A: Instructor materials

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### A1. Facilitator script (President of the IGC)

Read or paraphrase at the start (0:00–0:05):

“Welcome to the Intergovernmental Conference. You are each representing your government at the closing stage of a negotiation on deepening EU defence and security integration, prompted by the deteriorating security environment in and around Europe. On the table is the Treaty of Belfield, a draft amendment to Article 42 of the Treaty on European Union, the legal basis of the Common Security and Defence Policy. It does three linked things: it strengthens the EU Battlegroups by creating a standing force; it specifies how, through more armaments, logistics and joint training; and it says where the money comes from, by reallocating funds from the Union’s sustainability programmes. Your brief tells you where your country stands on each. Treaty change requires unanimity, so every one of you holds a veto: unless all eight delegations agree, nothing passes. You have fifty minutes. Read your brief, agree a one-minute opening pitch, and nominate a spokesperson. Your minute starts when I call you.”

Keep time strictly, move the tour de table along at one minute per delegation, and during deliberation nudge any delegation that is not engaging. About twelve minutes into deliberation, if the shared document is still empty, apply the “final day, media waiting” pressure.

### A2. Model outcome (the “revised edition”)

The delegations’ briefs are built so that certain coalitions form readily (a pro-defence bloc of Germany, Poland, the Netherlands, with France and Italy attached) while the funding source (reallocating sustainability money) draws wide resistance, and Hungary and Ireland have strong reasons to veto. A realistic negotiated outcome therefore strips out the most contested elements. In one run the delegations converged on the “revised edition” reproduced in Appendix B: the standing-force clause and the sustainability-funding clause were struck out, leaving only the softer commitments on armaments, interoperability and CSDP coordination. Even so watered down, the amendment can still fail if a single delegation vetoes. Use whichever outcome your class produces; both the pass and the deadlock illustrate the learning outcomes.

### A3. The three proposals at a glance (facilitator reference)

The draft treaty bundles three interlinked proposals. Delegations’ positions cluster as follows (summarised from the briefs; use to anticipate coalitions).

| Proposal                                                     | For                                                | Conditional / neutral                           | Against                                                                                      |
|--------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>WHAT: strengthen the Battlegroups (amend Art. 42 TEU)</b> | Germany, Poland, Netherlands, France, Italy        | Spain (persuadable)                             | Hungary, Ireland                                                                             |
| <b>HOW: standing force, armaments, interoperability</b>      | Germany, Poland, Netherlands, France, Italy, Spain | Ireland (if voluntary, humanitarian focus)      | Hungary                                                                                      |
| <b>WHERE FROM: reallocate sustainability funds</b>           | Poland                                             | France, Hungary (low climate priority but wary) | Netherlands, Ireland, Spain, Germany (moral objection), Italy prefers EU money over domestic |

The funding source is the fault line most likely to sink the treaty: sustainability leaders (the Netherlands, Ireland, Spain) resist reallocation strongly, so the wording of the funding clause (“shall” versus “may”, a cap, or a separate budget line) is where much of the bargaining should concentrate.

#### A4. Further reading

- Moravcsik, A. (1993) ‘Preferences and Power in the European Community: A Liberal Intergovernmentalist Approach’, *Journal of Common Market Studies*, 31(4), pp. 473–524. The classic account of state preferences and bargaining power in EU treaty negotiation.
- Consolidated version of the Treaty on European Union, Article 42 (Common Security and Defence Policy) and Article 48 (treaty revision procedures). Available at [eur-lex.europa.eu](http://eur-lex.europa.eu). The real legal basis the exercise amends and the real IGC procedure it simulates.
- European External Action Service, ‘EU Battlegroups’ factsheet, at [eeas.europa.eu](http://eeas.europa.eu). Background on what the Battlegroups actually are.
- European Council, ‘How the EU adopts and revises its treaties’. Available at [consilium.europa.eu](http://consilium.europa.eu). A short guide to the Intergovernmental Conference and the unanimity requirement.

## Appendix B: Student handouts and role briefs

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This appendix contains the draft treaty (the version put to negotiation), the “revised edition” (a model negotiated outcome, for the instructor to use as reference or to reveal in the debrief), and the eight country briefs, one per page. The treaty text and briefs are fictional and student-authored; the scenario is illustrative and simplified for teaching.

## **Treaty of Belfield 2025 (draft put to negotiation)**

### **Amending the Treaty on European Union (TEU)**

#### **PREAMBLE**

THE HIGH CONTRACTING PARTIES,

RESOLVED to strengthen the Union's capacity to act in response to external aggression, humanitarian crises, and internal challenges,

RECALLING the values of solidarity, human rights, and shared responsibility enshrined in the Treaties,

HAVE AGREED as follows:

#### **Article 1: Amendment to the Treaty on European Union**

In Article 42 TEU (Common Security and Defence Policy), insert:

“3a. Member States shall strengthen the EU Battlegroups as follows:

- a. Enhancement of size and capabilities:
- b. A standing force of 10,000 personnel shall be established, with contributions determined proportionally to population and military capacity.
- ii. Increase necessary armaments and logistical support to ensure operational readiness.
- iii. Strengthen interoperability and joint training exercises among Member States' forces.

b. Funding:

The necessary expenditures shall be financed through reallocation of Union sustainability funds, ensuring that funds are used exclusively for Union defence purposes.

c. Implementation:

All measures shall be executed under the framework of the Common Security and Defence Policy (CSDP) to guarantee coordinated EU-level defence capability.”

#### **Article 2: Final Provisions**

This Treaty shall be ratified in accordance with national constitutional requirements and shall enter into force on the first day of the month following the deposit of the last instrument of ratification.

## Treaty of Belfield 2025 (revised edition: a possible negotiated outcome)

*Instructor reference. This is one plausible watered-down result: the standing-force clause (a)(i) and the sustainability-funding clause (b) have been struck out, leaving the softer commitments. Reveal it in the debrief, or use it to compare against what your class produced.*

### Amending the Treaty on European Union (TEU)

#### PREAMBLE

THE HIGH CONTRACTING PARTIES,

RESOLVED to strengthen the Union's capacity to act in response to external aggression, humanitarian crises, and internal challenges,

RECALLING the values of solidarity, human rights, and shared responsibility enshrined in the Treaties,

HAVE AGREED as follows:

#### Article 1: Amendment to the Treaty on European Union

In Article 42 TEU (Common Security and Defence Policy), insert:

“3a. Member States shall strengthen the EU Battlegroups as follows:

a. Enhancement of size and capabilities:

*[clause (a)(i), the standing force of 10,000 personnel, struck out in negotiation]*

ii. Increase necessary armaments and logistical support to ensure operational readiness.

iii. Strengthen interoperability and joint training exercises among Member States' forces.

b. Funding:

*[the funding clause, reallocation of Union sustainability funds, struck out in negotiation]*

c. Implementation:

All measures shall be executed under the framework of the Common Security and Defence Policy (CSDP) to guarantee coordinated EU-level defence capability.”

#### Article 2: Final Provisions

This Treaty shall be ratified in accordance with national constitutional requirements and shall enter into force on the first day of the month following the deposit of the last instrument of ratification.

## France

Bienvenue. You are now France, the EU's second-largest member state by population and the second-largest net contributor to the EU budget. You have traditionally strong ties with Germany. Pressing domestic issues are immigration, the welfare state and the economy. There is serious political instability, with frequent changes of prime minister; the centrist presidential coalition holds no absolute majority, and a strengthened far right (Rassemblement National) is a live threat.

**Proposal 1: WHAT? Strengthen EU Battlegroups (amend Article 42 TEU).** *Very interested.*

- France generally favours deeper integration on military and energy security, and would seek a leadership role in this development. It could also help legitimise the presidency domestically.
- However: domestic instability is a constraint. Both the far right and far left are more Eurosceptic and inward-looking, and the government lacks an absolute majority.

**Proposal 2: HOW? Larger standing force, more armaments and logistics, stronger interoperability and joint training.** *Interested.*

- France already envisages a European armed presence on the Russian–European frontier; there have been (so far fruitless) discussions with Poland.
- However: the National Assembly would need to approve any additional French funds.

**Proposal 3: WHERE FROM? Reallocate from EU sustainability funds.** *Neutral.*

- In principle France supports the sustainability fund and its aims. But shifts in US politics and a struggling home market argue for using already-established funds rather than committing new money.
- However: some groups will resist moving money away from climate projects, and a politicised civil society may protest.

## Germany

Willkommen. You are now Germany, the EU's largest member state by population and its largest net contributor. You have traditionally strong economic and defence ties with France and the United States. Pressing issues are immigration, the economy, and foreign-policy positioning. The federal parliament has two chambers (Bundestag and Bundesrat); power rests with a coalition of conservatives (CDU/CSU) and social democrats (SPD), with the far-right AfD holding the second-largest bloc of seats.

**Proposal 1: WHAT? Strengthen EU Battlegroups (amend Article 42 TEU).** *Strongly in favour.*

- Since Russia's war of aggression, public concern about security has risen sharply, and the coalition is under pressure to deliver. Germany has already shifted its fiscal and austerity stance towards a more proactive security policy.
- However: public attention is intense, and some groups will resist reallocating funds from climate projects.

**Proposal 2: HOW? Larger standing force, more armaments and logistics, stronger interoperability and joint training.** *Interested.*

- German foreign policy has clearly changed: the 2025 defence budget (around €86 billion) is up roughly 28% on 2023, exceeding the NATO 2%-of-GDP target on a lasting basis, with the aim of building Europe's strongest conventional army. Military service is a live debate.
- However: with so much money involved, Germany will want to guard national control and sovereignty over military questions.

**Proposal 3: WHERE FROM? Reallocate from EU sustainability funds.** *Neutral.*

- On principle Germany would tend to object to reallocation, given public pressure for climate action.
- However: the geopolitical situation and rising tension with a shifting US may push it to reconsider, and internal cleavages (especially on the far right) cut against climate priorities.

## Hungary

Üdvözlöm. You are now Hungary, one of the ten states that joined in the 2004 enlargement. The economy has grown steadily since the end of communism but has struggled with high inflation and has not adopted the euro.

### **Proposal 1: WHAT? Strengthen EU Battlegroups (amend Article 42 TEU). *No interest.***

- The government has close ties with Russia and has opposed large-scale military aid to Ukraine. It generally opposes EU-wide defence funding, preferring independent national action to joint EU efforts, and in 2025 challenged the use of frozen Russian assets to fund Ukraine's defence.
- However: Hungary hosted and took part in the EU's largest military exercise in 2025.

### **Proposal 2: HOW? Larger standing force, more armaments and logistics, stronger interoperability and joint training. *No interest.***

- The government argues that raising military spending would cripple the economy. The Hungarian army is geared to national defence and is less suited to EU Battlegroups.
- However: Hungary is participating in an expanded EU Battlegroup led by Germany and the Netherlands.

### **Proposal 3: WHERE FROM? Reallocate from EU sustainability funds. *No interest.***

- Hungary ranks near the bottom of the OECD on environmental sustainability, has tried to block the EU's 2050 carbon-neutrality plan, and has campaigned against "climate hysteria" and EU-wide sustainability efforts. (This makes cutting sustainability funds a low-cost concession for Hungary, even though it opposes the treaty overall: a possible bargaining chip.)



## Ireland

Dia dhuit. You are now Ireland, a small, open economy heavily reliant on foreign direct investment, EU stability and EU funding. Domestic politics are shaped by a tradition of neutrality, severe housing pressures and rising sensitivity to migration. Crucially, any constitutional change requires a referendum, historically hard to pass; make this constraint clear to the other delegations. The parliament (Dáil) is dominated by centrist parties, with the main opposition on the left.

**Proposal 1: WHAT? Strengthen EU Battlegroups (amend Article 42 TEU).** *Not interested, with reservations.*

- Long-standing military neutrality; overseas deployment is constrained by the “Triple Lock” (UN approval, government decision, Dáil vote). Defence spending is very low (around 0.2% of GDP in 2024), and domestic politics are highly sensitive to deeper EU defence integration. Ireland would prefer any Battlegroup participation to be voluntary opt-in.
- However: Ireland would likely support enhanced training and interoperability for humanitarian and peacekeeping purposes, and new security challenges (Russian energy leverage, “shadow fleets” in Irish waters) are shifting opinion towards stronger sea and air defence and EU cooperation.

**Proposal 2: HOW? Larger standing force, more armaments and logistics, stronger interoperability and joint training.** *Interested, with conditions.*

- Ireland could support CSDP implementation if national decision-making and voluntary participation are preserved, prioritising humanitarian, maritime-security and crisis-response missions consistent with its long peacekeeping tradition.

**Proposal 3: WHERE FROM? Reallocate from EU sustainability funds.** *Not interested.*

- Ireland would strongly object: reallocation undermines climate and environmental commitments (net zero by 2050). A likely Irish move is to insist the wording change from “shall” to “may” allocate from sustainability funds, and to argue that defence should be financed under a dedicated EU budget line instead.
- However: some domestic debate questions whether defence should at times outweigh environmental goals.

## Italy

Benvenuti. You are now Italy, a large member state with a low-growth economy and high public debt, having only recently reached 2% of GDP on defence and expanded its armed forces after Russia's invasion of Ukraine.

### **Proposal 1: WHAT? Strengthen EU Battlegroups (amend Article 42 TEU). *Interested.***

- Italy has taken part in eight EU Battlegroups since 2005, notably the Spanish–Italian Amphibious Battlegroup and EUFOR, and joined the EU's SAFE security fund in 2025.
- However: the second-largest party in the governing coalition is seen as friendly to Russia.

### **Proposal 2: HOW? Larger standing force, more armaments and logistics, stronger interoperability and joint training. *Interested.***

- More EU spending on armaments and logistics would benefit EU firms and reduce reliance on US supply; Italy hosts two of Europe's largest defence companies (Leonardo and Fincantieri).
- However: the Italian army is reportedly undersized, so assigning extra personnel to EU Battlegroups may reduce readiness for current missions, and roughly 39% of Italians oppose European rearmament.

### **Proposal 3: WHERE FROM? Reallocate from EU sustainability funds. *Strong interest.***

- Italy received substantial sustainable investment from the European Investment Bank in 2024, but domestic climate investment stays below the EU average.
- Because Italy has the lowest public support in Europe for higher military spending, using EU funds (rather than domestic money) to pay for defence would ease economic and political concerns at home. Italy therefore favours the reallocation.

## The Netherlands

Gefeliciteerd. You are now the Netherlands, a proponent of European defence and security, fiscally disciplined, and an EU frontrunner on sustainability.

**Proposal 1: WHAT? Strengthen EU Battlegroups (amend Article 42 TEU).** *Highly interested.*

- A long-standing NATO proponent and current advocate of a stronger CSDP, the Netherlands already contributes consistently to Permanent Structured Cooperation (PESCO).

**Proposal 2: HOW? Larger standing force, more armaments and logistics, stronger interoperability and joint training.** *Highly interested.*

- Active in the European Defence Fund and in developing military technology, including collaboration with Ukraine. Current security concerns around Russia are seen as pressing.

**Proposal 3: WHERE FROM? Reallocate from EU sustainability funds.** *Strongly sceptical.*

- Despite firm support for more defence, moving money away from EU sustainability efforts may be too high a price. Given its centuries-long battle with the sea, the Netherlands is acutely wary of rising sea levels and is a leader in climate and renewable-energy policy.
- However: as an overall proponent of stronger defence, the Netherlands might accept a limited reallocation, or push for the money to be capped or drawn from somewhere else entirely.

## Poland

Gratulacje. You are now Poland. Poland has benefited greatly from EU membership but previously clashed with Brussels over the rule of law; a change of government has moved it back towards a cooperative stance. Most importantly, Poland's proximity to Russia gives it acute security concerns.

**Proposal 1: WHAT? Strengthen EU Battlegroups (amend Article 42 TEU).** *Highly interested.*

- Given its wariness of Russian aggression, Poland sees strengthening the CSDP as an urgent priority.

**Proposal 2: HOW? Larger standing force, more armaments and logistics, stronger interoperability and joint training.** *Highly interested.*

- Deeper collaboration with other member states directly addresses Poland's security concerns, and a larger, better-backed Battlegroup lends credibility to Polish defence. Poland's frontline position is leverage: opening collaboration could strategically position other member states' forces alongside its own.

**Proposal 3: WHERE FROM? Reallocate from EU sustainability funds.** *Highly interested.*

- Poland is not at the forefront of sustainability and has little pressure to change course, though it has made cautious moves into areas like nuclear power. Its security needs are urgent and, in its view, should be met at almost any cost, so it is comfortable funding defence from sustainability money. It might sympathise with others' objections and be open to alternatives if that secures a deal.

## Spain

Bienvenidos. You are now Spain, a member state with a mixed economy whose biggest trading partners are France and Germany (making it EU-reliant). Spain was sixth in the world for military spending in absolute terms in 2024 but the lowest relative spender in NATO. A socialist-led minority government is under pressure from a strong conservative opposition and has been unable to pass the national budget. Spain is committed to a “just” green transition and is a major recipient of the NextGenerationEU fund.

**Proposal 1: WHAT? Strengthen EU Battlegroups (amend Article 42 TEU).** *Slightly against, but persuadable.*

- The government depends on left-wing parties, some opposed to NATO in principle, and there is a strong post-Franco tradition of pacifism; a push to the NATO 5%-of-GDP target divides the coalition. The government worked (with Italy) to dilute the military edge of “ReArm Europe”, rebranded “Readiness 2030”.
- However: the government has firmly condemned Russia’s invasion of Ukraine and sent tanks, planes and training. There is some cross-party consensus on modest defence increases, and Spain risks marginalisation if France and Germany drive a coordinated defence agenda. Spain has a Battlegroup history with Italy (a natural negotiating partner).

**Proposal 2: HOW? Larger standing force, more armaments and logistics, stronger interoperability and joint training.** *Slightly in favour.*

- Spain supports deeper EU defence integration as a route to “strategic autonomy” amid uncertainty over US supply, and prefers EU-led frameworks. Its defence industry (for example Indra) could benefit economically through the European Defence Fund.
- However: this issue could fracture the left-wing coalition, and Spain worries its defence industry could be exploited by “free-riding” partners.

**Proposal 3: WHERE FROM? Reallocate from EU sustainability funds.** *Not in favour.*

- Reallocating away from green-transition funds (of which Spain is a major beneficiary) runs directly against government priorities; the government has tried to fold climate into its defence agenda rather than trade one for the other. Shifting money towards a polluting arms industry is a hard sell in a climate-conscious country hit by repeated climate disasters.